SHIBANI GHOSH, 42
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The Green Litigator

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Supreme Court-appointed amicus curiae in the long-running M.C. Mehta air pollution case, Shibani Ghosh has shaped India's environmental jurisprudence through litigation, scholarship and policy research



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

When Shibani Ghosh learnt in 2024 that an elephant was to be relocated from Jorhat in Assam to Delhi's Greater Kailash, one question struck her immediately: where would the animal be housed? The answer was Sainik Farms, a densely built-up, water-stressed neighbourhood hardly suited to an elephant. Already pursuing a case in the Delhi High Court against the transfer of elephants for religious purposes, she and her colleagues sought an urgent intervention on behalf of an animal welfare organisation. The court ordered an inspection and halted the relocation for then. "One elephant at a time," she says of that outcome—something that still defines her approach to environmental law.

Born in 1983 to architect parents, Shibani decided while still in Class 8 that she wanted to protect forests and wildlife. Her family backed that early ambition, a support she continues to find in her lawyer husband and their seven-year-old daughter. After graduating from The West Bengal National University of Juridical Sciences, Kolkata, she won a Rhodes Scholarship to Oxford, where she studied law and environmental change.

A stint with then Central Information Commissioner Shailesh Gandhi in 2008 gave her an insider's view of how public institutions function—and where they often fall short. Her 13-year association with the Centre for Policy Research shaped her as both researcher and litigator. In 2019, she edited the widely used open-access volume *Indian Environmental Law: Key Concepts and Principles*, now taught in universities and cited by the Supreme Court.

A Supreme Court Advocate-on-Record, Shibani is one of three amici curiae assisting the apex court in the decades-old M.C. Mehta case, which continues to shape pollution-control measures across the National Capital Region. For Shibani, the central environmental battle today is not only enforcing existing legal safeguards but preventing their silent erosion through exemptions, diluted definitions and perfunctory public consultations. ■

—Kaushik Deka

HER ADVICE

"Aspiring environmental lawyers should acquire as many skills as possible, remain open to learning from people who may not speak their professional language—panchayat members, scientists, project-affected families, etc.—and, above all, come prepared"